

INTRODUCTION TO MEDIA STUDIES

Student Study Notes – Mid-Term Examination
Open Elective | For Non-Media Students

These notes cover the major concepts required for the Mid-Term examination in simple language, with examples for easy understanding.

1. What is Media?

The word **media** refers to the different channels or tools used to communicate information, ideas, messages and entertainment to people. Media connects individuals, groups, institutions and society.

Examples: Newspapers, magazines, books, radio, television, films, websites, social media, mobile applications and podcasts.

Major types:

- **Print Media:** Newspapers, magazines and books.
- **Electronic Media:** Radio and television.
- **Digital Media:** Websites, mobile applications, online news, podcasts and streaming services.
- **Social Media:** Platforms where users create, share and interact with content.

Remember: Media = Channels used to communicate information and messages.

2. What is Communication?

Communication is the process of sharing information, ideas, feelings or meaning between people. For communication to happen, there is normally someone sending a message and someone receiving it.

Example: A teacher explains a concept to students. Teacher = Sender; Explanation = Message; Students = Receivers. If students respond, that response becomes feedback.

3. Basic Elements of Communication

Sender: Person or organisation that starts the communication.

Message: Information being communicated.

Channel: Medium through which the message travels, such as telephone, email, television, radio or WhatsApp.

Receiver: Person or group receiving the message.

Feedback: Response given by the receiver.

Noise: Anything that interferes with communication, such as poor internet, weak mobile signal, disturbing sound, unclear language or technical problems.

Easy Formula: Sender → Message → Channel → Receiver → Feedback. Noise can disturb this process.

4. Shannon–Weaver Model of Communication

The **Shannon–Weaver Model** is a basic model used to understand how a message moves from a source to a receiver through a channel. Noise may interfere with the message.

Example: You tell a friend on the phone, “Meet me at 5 PM,” but a poor network causes the message to be heard incorrectly. The poor network is noise.

Key Point: The model helps explain message transmission and the problem of noise.

5. Mass Communication

Mass communication is communication in which a message is sent to a large number of people through media. Examples include television news, newspapers, radio broadcasts, online news websites and public information

campaigns.

Remember: Mass Communication = Communication with a large audience through media.

6. Functions of Media

Media performs important functions in society:

- **Information:** News, weather, government announcements and current events.
- **Education:** Educational programmes, online lectures, documentaries and podcasts.
- **Entertainment:** Movies, television programmes, music and games.
- **Public Awareness:** Road safety, environment, health, voting and disaster preparedness.

7. Agenda-Setting Theory

Agenda-Setting Theory explains how media can influence which issues people consider important. When media repeatedly gives attention to an issue, audiences may perceive that issue as more important.

Example: If news media continuously reports unemployment, people may begin to consider unemployment one of the country's most important problems.

Remember: More media attention → Greater perceived importance. Media can influence what we think about.

8. Cultivation Theory

Cultivation Theory explains how long-term and repeated exposure to media content can influence people's perception of reality. It is especially associated with long-term television exposure.

Example: A person who regularly watches crime and violence programmes may begin to believe the real world is extremely dangerous.

Remember: Repeated media exposure → Can influence perception of reality.

9. Diffusion of Innovations Theory

The **Diffusion of Innovations Theory**, associated with **Everett Rogers**, explains how new ideas, technologies, products or practices spread through society over time.

Innovations can include smartphones, digital payments, AI tools, electric vehicles and online learning. Adoption usually begins with a small group and gradually spreads to wider society.

Remember: Everett Rogers → Diffusion of Innovations → Spread of new ideas and technologies.

10. Innovators

In Diffusion of Innovations Theory, **innovators** are people who are among the first to try new ideas or technologies. For example, people who immediately experiment with a newly released AI application may be considered innovators.

Simple Sequence: New Innovation → First Users → More Users → Wider Adoption.

11. Public Sphere

The concept of the **Public Sphere** is strongly associated with **Jürgen Habermas**. It refers to a space where citizens discuss issues of public importance. It can exist through newspapers, television discussions, public meetings, online forums and digital platforms.

Example: Citizens debating the advantages and disadvantages of an environmental policy.

Remember: Public Sphere = Space for public discussion and debate.

12. Health Belief Model

The **Health Belief Model (HBM)** helps explain why people make health-related decisions. People may be more likely to take preventive action when they believe they are at risk, the health problem is serious, action will help, and barriers can be managed.

Applications: Vaccination, exercise, healthy diet, screening and disease prevention.

Remember: Health Belief Model → Understanding health decisions and preventive behaviour.

13. Evolution of Media

Media has changed continuously with society and technology. A simple evolution is: **Print → Electronic → Digital → Interactive/Social Media**. Each new medium changed how information is created, distributed and consumed.

14. Print Media

Print media is one of the oldest major forms of mass media. It includes newspapers, books and magazines. The development of the **printing press** made large-scale reproduction and distribution of information easier.

Newspapers became important sources of news, opinions, advertisements and political information.

Remember: Books + Newspapers + Magazines = Print Media.

15. Rise of Electronic Media

Technology enabled communication through electronic systems. Two important electronic mass media are **radio** and **television**.

16. Radio

Radio communicates mainly through **sound/audio**. It became an important medium for news, music, entertainment, education and public information. Its strength is the ability to reach large audiences through audio broadcasting.

17. Television

Television combines **sound and moving images**, making it an audio-visual mass medium. It is used for news, entertainment, education, sports, advertising and public information.

18. Internet and Digital Media

The internet enabled information to travel quickly across geographical boundaries. Digital media includes websites, online newspapers, mobile applications, streaming platforms, podcasts and social media.

Important features include **speed, global reach, multimedia content, user participation and interactivity**.

19. Interactivity

Interactivity is an important feature of digital media. Traditional mass communication was often largely one-way, while digital media enables audiences to like, comment, share, reply, upload and create content. Audiences can therefore become active participants.

20. Social Media

Social media allows users to **create, share and interact with content**. Unlike many traditional media systems, ordinary users can become content creators as well as consumers. A student can record, edit and upload a video and receive immediate feedback from an audience.

21. Traditional Media vs Digital Media

Traditional and digital media often coexist. Newspapers may have print editions, websites, apps, social media accounts, videos and podcasts. Digital media generally offers greater speed, participation and interactivity.

22. How Media Has Evolved

A simplified timeline is:

Books & Newspapers → Radio → Television → Internet → Websites & Digital Media → Social Media & Mobile Media

The major shift is from largely one-way mass communication toward increasingly interactive and participatory communication.

23. Important Names to Remember

Everett Rogers – Diffusion of Innovations Theory

Jürgen Habermas – Public Sphere

Shannon and Weaver – Shannon–Weaver Model of Communication

24. Key Terms for Examination

Media: Channels used to communicate information.

Communication: Sharing information and meaning.

Sender: Person who sends a message.

Receiver: Person who receives a message.

Message: Information being communicated.

Channel: Medium carrying the message.

Feedback: Receiver's response.

Noise: Anything interfering with communication.

Mass Communication: Communication with a large audience through media.

Interactivity: Ability of users to respond and participate.

Diffusion: Process through which an innovation spreads.

Innovators: People among the first to adopt an innovation.

25. Quick Revision

Communication: Sender → Message → Channel → Receiver → Feedback

Functions: Information + Education + Entertainment + Awareness

Media Evolution: Print → Radio → Television → Internet → Digital/Social Media

Agenda Setting: Importance of issues

Cultivation: Long-term media exposure and perception of reality

Diffusion of Innovations: Everett Rogers; spread of new ideas and technologies

Public Sphere: Public discussion and debate; Jürgen Habermas

Health Belief Model: Health behaviour, risk and preventive action

26. Theory Comparison – Quick Reference

Concept	Main Idea	Simple Example
Agenda Setting	Media influences which issues appear important	Repeated unemployment coverage
Cultivation Theory	Repeated exposure can shape perception of reality	Heavy crime viewing makes the world seem dangerous
Diffusion of Innovations	New ideas and technologies spread through society	Gradual adoption of smartphones
Public Sphere	Citizens discuss matters of public importance	Public debate on environmental policy
Health Belief Model	Explains health-related decisions and behaviour	Taking preventive action to reduce health risk

27. One-Line Memory Guide

Shannon-Weaver = Communication Process

Agenda Setting = Importance of Issues

Cultivation = Media Exposure & Perception

Everett Rogers = Diffusion of Innovations

Habermas = Public Sphere

Health Belief Model = Health Decisions